Key Messages

- Despite below-average production, fall harvests are temporarily improving the availability of certain local food products in some areas. However, gang-related violence and the rise in illicit tolls imposed by these groups are disrupting market supply chains, resulting in higher prices. As a result, widespread Crisis (IPC Phase 3) food insecurity continues in Haiti, although the number of food-insecure people across the country has fallen slightly compared with October and November. However, increased insecurity in Cité Soleil continues to keep it in an Emergency (IPC Phase 4) situation.

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- Despite continued appreciation of the national currency against the USD, food commodity prices remain high compared with monthly, annual, and five-year trends, mainly due to disruptions in the supply chain. In addition, high transaction costs due to increasingly high illegal tolls imposed by armed gangs on national roads are contributing to atypically high prices.
- Except for the Cap-Haïtien and Ouanaminthe markets, where the relative availability of the fall black bean harvests led to a fall in prices, bean prices rose by up to 27.7 percent in November compared to October, particularly in the departments affected by bad weather in November. In addition, pigeon peas and sorghum are currently being harvested almost everywhere, although prices remain high.

Current Situation

Security situation: According to a report by the United Nations Integrated Office in Haiti (BINUH), quoted by the Haiti Partners Liaison and Security Office (PLSO) ↗, almost 80 percent of the Port-au-Prince metropolitan area is either under the influence of armed gangs or directly controlled by them. According to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR), there were more than 8,000 victims (3,960 dead, 1,432 injured, and 2,951 kidnapped) from January to December 8, 2023, far exceeding the number of victims in 2022. Cases of violence are particularly high in Port-au-Prince and Croix-des-Bouquets (Figure 1).

According to the Center for Analysis and Research on Human Rights (CARDH), 362 cases of abduction were recorded in the third quarter of 2023, an increase of more than 140 percent compared to the second quarter, when 150 abductions were recorded. Gang violence continues to disrupt the to the closure of the border with the Dominican Republic, transportation costs for imported fertilizers have increased.

In the Centre department, beans and especially pigeon peas have been harvested. However, low rainfall and a reduction in soil preparation activities have led to below-average production, reducing the local supply of food products. Rainfall is currently relatively regular in Nord-Ouest, where manioc, banana, yam, and peas have been harvested. In Artibonite, beans are being planted in the upper Artibonite, and the maize harvest is under way. In Nippes, the poor pigeon pea harvest and lack of rainfall in December are contributing to low local food availability.

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Markets and commodity prices: Markets continue to operate throughout the country, except for those in the Port-au-Prince metropolitan area, such as Croix-des-Bossales and Croix-des-Bouquets, among others, due to the renewed upsurge in clashes between gangs in and around downtown Port-au-Prince. This situation is affecting the movement of people and goods across the country. In addition to imported food, seasonal crops such as pigeon peas, roots, tubers, cereals, and other seasonal produce have declined with winter activities. This explains the rise in prices of all basic food products, both local and imported, in November (see Figure 2).

Furthermore, despite the reopening of the border by the Dominican authorities, activities and trade in basic food products between the two countries remain officially limited. This is increasing smuggling across the Haitian-Dominican border, to the point where Dominican products such as eggs, oils, condiments, and wheat flour are appearing in local markets. Despite their availability, they are sold on the black market at exorbitant prices. Local retailers are continuing to increase their prices in Haitian markets. In addition to insecurity and the reduced availability of local food products, this is one of the main causes of the rise in prices of basic foodstuffs in November compared with October.

On December 14, Haitian and Dominican citizens damaged and removed the Haitian barrier at the border between Ouanaminthe and Dajabon in order to facilitate trade. Despite the presence of customs officers and border police (Polifront), the Haitian barrier at the Haitian-Dominican border was forced open the very next day, and commercial activities resumed at the bi-national market on the Dajabon side. The Haitian departmental authorities have replaced the barrier but have not yet announced whether they intend to keep the border open or closed.

Nationwide, the prices of grain maize and dried black beans monitored by FEWS NET fluctuated upwards by an average of 6.2 and 8 percent,